

See discussions, stats, and author profiles for this publication at:
<https://www.researchgate.net/publication/258144301>

Real Punks and Pretenders

Article *in* Journal of Contemporary Ethnography · October 1987

DOI: 10.1177/0891241687163006

CITATIONS

83

READS

653

1 author:



Kathryn J Fox

University of Vermont

25 PUBLICATIONS **391** CITATIONS

SEE PROFILE

Journal of Contemporary Ethnography

<http://jce.sagepub.com/>

Real Punks and Pretenders: The Social Organization of a Counterculture

Kathryn Joan Fox

Journal of Contemporary Ethnography 1987 16: 344

DOI: 10.1177/0891241687163006

The online version of this article can be found at:

<http://jce.sagepub.com/content/16/3/344>

Published by:



<http://www.sagepublications.com>

**Additional services and information for *Journal of Contemporary Ethnography* can be
found at:**

Email Alerts: <http://jce.sagepub.com/cgi/alerts>

Subscriptions: <http://jce.sagepub.com/subscriptions>

Reprints: <http://www.sagepub.com/journalsReprints.nav>

Permissions: <http://www.sagepub.com/journalsPermissions.nav>

Citations: <http://jce.sagepub.com/content/16/3/344.refs.html>

>> **Version of Record** - Oct 1, 1987

What is This?

Very little has been written from a sociological perspective about the punk counterculture in the United States. Further, few studies of antiestablishment style cultures deal with their implicit social organization. In this essay I describe and analyze the informal stratification of a local punk community. I based members' positions within the hierarchy on their perceived level of commitment to the scene. Within the group, three categories of punks emerged: hardcore punks, softcore punks, and preppie punks. Another type appeared that was peripheral to the scene, referred to as "spectators." In discussing each type, I describe their appearance, lifestyle, and attitude and how these factors affected members' positions in the larger scene. I conclude by analyzing the function of each group for the social organization of the scene, and for antiestablishment cultures more generally.

REAL PUNKS AND PRETENDERS

The Social Organization of a Counterculture

KATHRYN JOAN FOX

MODERN WESTERN SOCIETY has been characterized by a variety of antiestablishment style countercultures following in succession (i.e., the Teddy Boys of 1953-1957, the Mods and Rockers of 1964-1966, the Skinheads of 1967-1970, and the Punk Rockers of the late 1970s; Taylor, 1982). The punk culture is but the latest in this series. Since most studies of youth- and style-oriented groups are British (Frith, 1982), very little has been written from a sociological perspective about punks in the United States. This study is an attempt to fill that void.

Whether or not the punk scene in the United States could be legitimately classified as a social movement is debatable. Most writers on this contemporary phenomenon agree that

AUTHOR'S NOTE: I would like to thank Peter and Patti Adler for their thoughtful readings of earlier drafts of this article. I would also like to thank the three anonymous reviewers for their helpful criticisms. Further, I am indebted to E. Burke Rochford, Jr., and David Matza for their insights. Finally, I am grateful to John Torpey for encouragement as well as editorial assistance.

JOURNAL OF CONTEMPORARY ETHNOGRAPHY, Vol. 16 No. 3, October 1987 344-370
© 1987 Sage Publications, Inc.

American punks have a more amorphous, less articulated ideological agenda than punks elsewhere (Brake, 1985; Street, 1986). While the punk scene in England responded to youth unemployment and working-class problems, the phenomenon in the United States was more closely connected to style than to politics. Street (1986: 175) notes that even for English punks, "politics was part of the style." I would argue that this was even more the case for American punks. The consciousness of the youth in the United States did not parallel the identification with the plight of youth found in Europe. Nonetheless, the "style" code for punks in the United States contained an insistent element of conflict with the dominant value system. The consensual values among the punks, as ambiguous as they were, could best be understood by their contradictory quality with reference to mainstream society. In this respect, punk in America fit the definition of a "counterculture" offered by Yinger (1982: 22-23). According to this definition, the salient feature of a counterculture is its contrariness. Further, as opposed to individual deviant behavior, punks constituted a counterculture in that they shared a specific normative system. Certain behaviors were considered punk, while others were not. Indeed, style was the message and the means of expression. Observation of behaviors that were consistent with punk sensibilities were viewed as indicative of punk "beliefs." These behaviors, along with verbal pronouncements, verified commitment. Within the groups of punks I studied, the degree of commitment to the counterculture lifestyle was the variable that determined placement within the hierarchy of the local scene.

Previous portrayals of youthful, antiestablishment style cultures have discussed their norms and values (Berger, 1967; Davis, 1970; Hebdige, 1981; Yablonsky, 1968), their relationship to conventional society (Cohen, 1972; Douglas, 1970; Flacks, 1967), their focal concerns and ideology (Flacks, 1967; Miller, 1958), and their relationship to social class (Brake, 1980; Hall and Jefferson, 1975; Mungham and

Pearson, 1976). With the exception of Davis and Munoz (1968), Kinsey (1982), and Yablonsky (1959), few of the studies of antiestablishment, countercultural groups discuss their implicit stratification. In this essay I will describe and analyze the various categories of membership in the punk scene and show how members of these strata differ with regard to their ideology, appearance, taste, lifestyle, and commitment.

I begin by discussing how I became interested in the topic and the methods I employed to gain access to the group and to gather data. I then offer a description of the setting and the people who frequented this scene. Next I offer a structural portrayal of the social organization of this punk scene, showing how the layers of membership form. I then examine each of the three membership categories (hardcore punks, softcore punks, and preppie punks), as well as the spectator category, focusing on the differences in their attitudes, behavior, and involvement with this antiestablishment style culture. I conclude by outlining the contributions each of these types of members makes to the continuing existence of the punk movement and, more broadly, by describing the relation between the punk counterculture and conventional society.

METHODS

My interest in the punk movement dates back to 1978. At that time, I attended a local punk bar fairly regularly and wore my hair and clothing in "punk" style, albeit not the radical version. I also visited a major northeastern city at about that same time, when the punk scene was in full flower, and spent several nights visiting what are now famous punk hangouts. My early interest and involvement in this scene laid the groundwork for this study, as it permitted me to gain knowledge of the punk vernacular, styles, and motives. The research continued, with active, weekly participation, through the middle of 1986. I have

continued to keep a close watch on national trends and developments in punk culture. Further, I continually frequented local punk bars in an effort to deepen my understanding and to observe the decline of this counterculture. However, I conducted the bulk of my interviews in the fall of 1983 over a period of about two months. During that time, I attended "punk night" at a local bar once a week. In addition, I was invited to other punk functions, such as parties, midnight jam sessions, and public property destruction events. I thereby observed approximately 30 members of this movement with some degree of regularity. I used mainly observational techniques, along with some participation. Although I frequented numerous punk gatherings, my participatory role was constrained by the limited time I spent there. I also had to tread a line between covert and overt roles. While some people knew I was researching this setting, I could not reveal this to others because they might have denied me further access to the group. This created a problem, much the same as that experienced by Henslin (1972) and Adler (1985), in that I had to be careful about what I said and to whom I confided my research interests. This "tightrope effect" severely limited my active participation in the scene.

Nevertheless, by following the investigative research techniques advocated by Douglas (1976), I was able to gain the trust of some key members. I tried to establish friendly relations by running errands for them, buying them drinks and food, and driving them to pick up their welfare checks and food stamps. After several weeks, when I began to be recognized, I was able to broach the topic of doing interviews with several people. I formally interviewed nine people at locations outside the bar. These tape-recorded interviews were unstructured and open-ended. Additionally, I conducted 15 informal interviews at the bar. Finally, I had countless conversations with members, nonmembers, interested bystanders, and social scientists who had an interest in the punk counterculture. In all, my somewhat punk

appearance, similar age, regularity at the scene, and apparent acceptance of their lifestyle allowed me to move within the scene freely and easily.

SETTING

The research took place in a small cowboy bar, "The Glass Gun," which was transformed into a punk bar one night a week. The bar was situated in a southwestern city with a population of about 500,000. The city itself is located in the "Bible Belt," characterized by conservative religious and political views. The bar was a small, dark, and dilapidated place. There was a stage area where the bands played, surrounded by a wooden rail. Wobbly tables and torn chairs formed a U-shape around the stage. There was a pool table in the corner, which the punks rarely used. Most of the patrons of the club stood at or near the bar.

For the punks in this city, the Glass Gun was the only place to congregate regularly at that time. On these designated nights, local punk bands played to an audience of about 20 people; some were punks, others were not. The typical audience ranged in age from about 16 to 30, although a few were younger or older. Basically, the punk counterculture was a youth phenomenon. It seemed to attract young, single, mobile people. Snow et al. (1980) have suggested that these characteristics make a person more "structurally available" for movement recruitment. Within the punk scene the number of men and women was fairly equal.

The punk style codes were somewhat diverse. Different styles existed for different kinds of punk. Pfohl (1985: 381) has referred to Hebdige's description of punk style as "the outrageous disfigurement of commonsensical images of aesthetics and beauty and the abrasive, destructive codes of punk style. These are aesthetic inversions of the normal, or consensus-producing, rituals of the dominant culture's style." The basic identifiable element was a subculturally

accepted punk hairstyle. These ranged from a very short, uneven haircut, sticking straight up in front, to an American Indian mohawk style, to a shaven head. Along with the haircut, a punk fashion prevailed. The two were inextricably associated. The fashion ranged from torn, faded jeans, T-shirts, and army boots to expensive leather outfits.

The punk dress code was also fairly androgynous. There was no real distinction between male and female fashions. Both men and women wore faded jeans, although leather pants and miniskirts were also quite common among the women. The middle-class punk women, who tended to be students, dressed in a more traditionally feminine manner, glorifying and exaggerating the "glamour girl" image reminiscent of the sixties. This included tight skirts, teased hair, and dark, heavy makeup. The other punk women identified with a more masculine, working-class image, deemphasizing their feminine attributes. Both sexes also wore and admired leather jackets. It was also quite common to see both men and women with multiple pierced earrings all the way around the outside of their ears. Men sometimes wore eye makeup as well. (One man wore miniskirts, makeup, and rhinestones. However, this type of behavior occurred infrequently.) Basically, punk style ran counter to what the dominant culture would deem aesthetically pleasing. One major reason punks dressed as they did was to set themselves apart and to make themselves recognizable. The image consisted of dark, drab clothing, short, spiky, "homemade" haircuts, and blank, bored, expressionless faces reminiscent of those of concentration camp prisoners.¹ The punks created a new aesthetic that revealed their lack of hope, cynicism, and rejection of societal norms.

THE SOCIAL ORGANIZATION OF THE PUNK SCENE

Like the youth gangs that Yablonsky (1962) studied, members of this local punk scene constituted a "near-

group." The membership was impermanent and shifting, members' expectations were not always clearly defined, consensus within the group was problematic, and the leadership was vague. Yet out of this uncertainty surfaced an apparent consensus about the stratification of the local community and the roles of the three types of members and peripheral hangers-on who participated in this scene. These four typologies can be hierarchically arranged by the presence (or absence) and intensity of their commitment to the punk counterculture and their consequent display of the punk affectations and belief system. They thus formed a series of outwardly expanding concentric circles, with the most committed members occupying the core, inner roles, and the least involved participants falling around the periphery.

Starting from the center, the number of members occupying each stratum progressively increased as the commitment level of the participants diminished. The categories to which I refer come from the terms used by the participants themselves.² The *hardcore punks* were the most involved in the scene, and derived the greatest amount of prestige from their association with it. They set the trends and standards for the rest of the members. The *softcore punks* were less dedicated to the antiestablishment lifestyle and to a permanent association with this counterculture, yet their degree of involvement was still high. They were greater in number and, while highly respected by the less committed participants, did not occupy the same social status within the group as the hardcores. Their roles were, in a sense, dictated by the hardcores, whom they admired, and who defined the acceptable norms and values. The *preppie punks* were only minimally committed, constituting the largest portion of the actual membership. They were held in low esteem by the two core groups, following their lead but lacking the inner conviction and degree of participation necessary to be considered socially desirable within the scene. Finally, the *spectators* made up the largest part of the crowd at any public setting where a punk event

transpired. They were not truly members of the group, and therefore did not necessarily revere the actions and dedication of the hardcores as did the two intermediary groups. They did not attempt to follow the standards of those committed to this near-group. They were merely outsiders with an interest in the punk scene.

These four groups constituted the range of participants who attended and were involved with, to varying degrees, the punk counterculture. I will now examine in greater detail their styles, beliefs, practices, intentions, and roles in the scene.

PUNKS AND COMMITMENT

At the time of this study, the group of punks was small and disorganized. The number of people at any given punk event had steadily declined since my first encounters with the scene in 1978. Punk was no longer a new phenomenon, and this particularly conservative community did not provide a very conducive atmosphere for a large countercultural group to flourish. Every member of the group expressed dissatisfaction and boredom with the events (or rather, lack of events) within the scene. Even within the limits necessitated by the relatively small size of the group, there was a great deal of variation in terms of punk roles and characteristics. The qualities attributed to the different roles were based upon commitment to the scene. The punks' perceptions of levels of commitment were based principally on their evaluation of physical appearances and lifestyles. The punks categorized members of the scene on these bases and invented terms to describe them. The four types of participants, described above, varied according to their level of commitment to the scene.

HARDCORE PUNKS

Hardcore punks made up the smallest portion of the scene's membership. In the eyes of the other punks,

though, they were the essence of the local movement. The hardcores expressed the greatest loyalty to the punk scene as a whole. Although the hardcores embodied punk fashion and lifestyle codes to the highest degree, their commitment to the counterculture went much deeper than that. As one hardcore punk said:

There's been so much pure bullshit written about punks. Everyone is shown with a safety pin in their ear or blue hair. The public image is too locked into the fashion. That has nothin' to do with punk, really. . . . For me, it is just my way of life.

The feature that distinguished hardcore punks from other punks was their belief in, and concern for, the punk counterculture. In this sense, the hardcore punks had gone beyond commitment; they had undergone the process of conversion (Snow et al., 1986). In other words, not only did they have membership status, but they believed in and espoused the virtues and ideology of the counterculture. Although many hardcores differed on what the counterculture's core values were, they all expressed some concern with punk ideology. These values were ambiguous at best, but included a distinctly antiestablishment, anarchistic sentiment. Street (1986: 175) has described punk as celebrating chaos and "a life lived only for the moment." The associated value system of punk was understood by the incorporation of cynicism and a distrust of authority. In keeping with other subcultures that intentionally distinguish themselves from the dominant culture, the punk aesthetic, lifestyle, and worldview directly confronted those of the larger society and its traditions. While the other types of punks made no reference to group beliefs or values, the hardcores revered the counterculture. For them, being punk had a profound effect on all aspects of their lives. As one hardcore said:

There are a lot of punks around, even real punks, who don't mean it. At least, not all the way, like I do. Sometimes I feel so good about

punk that I cry. And when I see people getting into some band with real punk lyrics, it's like a religious experience.

It was precisely this belief in "punk" as an external reality, like a higher good, that set the hardcores apart. Similar to Sykes and Matza's (1958) "appeal to higher loyalties," hardcore punks based their rejection of conventional society on their commitment to their antiestablishment lifestyles and beliefs. This imbued their self-identity with a sense of seriousness and purpose. Unlike other punks, they did not view their punk identity as a temporary role or a transitory fashion, but as a permanent way of life. As one hardcore member said:

Punk didn't influence me to be the way I am much. I was always this way inside. When I came into punk, it was what I needed all my life. I could finally be myself.

Without exception, the hardcores reported having always held the values or qualities associated with the punk counterculture. The local scene, in fact, was just a convenient way of expressing these ideas collectively. Perhaps the most essential value professed by the punks was a genuine disdain for the conventional system. Their use of the term *system* here referred to a general concept of the way the material world works: bureaucracies, power structures, and competition for scarce goods. This "system" further referred to the ethic of deferred gratification, conventional hard work for profit, and the concept of private property. While this bears some similarity to Flacks's (1967) discussion of the student movement and Davis's (1970) portrayal of hippies, hardcore punks generally had a disdain for these earlier youth subcultures. There was a general attitude among punks of the need to create and maintain their own distinctive style. Kinsey found this same feature in the antibourgeois "killum and eatum" subculture. According to Kinsey (1982: 316), "K and E offered an attractive setting as its ideology presented an excellent

vehicle for expressing hostility toward conventional society." This contempt for authority and the conventional culture was, in fact, such an essential value for the punks that if one expressed prosystem sentiments or support for the present administration, one could not be considered a committed member, no matter how well one looked the part. Overt behavioral and physical attributes, though, were major ways hardcore punks showed disdain for the system. Particular characteristics were essential for consideration as hardcores. Most fundamentally, a verbal commitment to punk values and the punk scene, in general, was required. For example, John, the epitome of a hardcore punk, claimed to hate the system. He talked about the inequality of the system quite often. In John's words:

Punk set me free. It let me out of the system. I can walk the streets now and do what I want and not live by the demands of the system. When I walk the streets, I am a punk, not a bum.

However, this verbal pronouncement had to be backed by a certain lifestyle that further indicated commitment to the group. This lifestyle consisted of escaping the system in some way. Almost all of the hardcores were unemployed and lived in old, abandoned houses or moved into the homes of friends for periods of time. Some survived from the charity of sycophantic, less committed punks. Others worked in jobs that they considered to be outside the system, such as musicians in rock bands or artists.

Another central feature of the lifestyle was the hardcores' use of dangerous drugs. Many hardcores indulged heavily in sniffing glue. Glue was inexpensive and readily available to the punks. Its use also symbolized the self-destructive, nihilistic attitude of hardcores and their desire to live outside of society's norms. As one member said:

It is kind of like a competition, a show-off thing. . . . See who has the most guts by seeing who can burn his brain up first. It is like a total lack of care about anything, really.

This closely corresponds to Davis and Munoz's (1968) description of "freaks." Both punks and freaks were "in search of drug kicks as such, especially if [their] craving carries [them] to the point of drug abuse where [their] health, sanity and relations with intimates are jeopardized" (Davis and Munoz, 1968: 306). Again, here we see a rejection of anything the larger society sees as "sensible."

However, the most salient feature of the hardcore lifestyle was the radical physical appearance. In every case, people who were labeled as hardcore had drastically altered some aspect of their bodies. For example, in addition to the hairstyles discussed earlier, they often had tattoos, such as swastikas, on their arms or faces. Brake (1985: 78) has referred to the use of the swastika as a symbol for punks that was actually devoid of any political significance. Rather, the swastika was a "symbol of contempt" employed as a means of offending the traditional culture. The hardcore punks did their best to alienate themselves from the larger society.

According to Kanter (1972), the first requisite in the principle of a gestalt sociology is that a group forms maximum commitment to this higher ideal by sharply differentiating itself from the larger society. The hardcore members did this by going through the initiation rite of passage: semipermanently altering their appearance. As one hardcore said:

Did you see Russell's mohawk? I'm so glad for him. He finally decided to go for it. Now he is a punk everywhere . . . no way he can hide it now.

This was similar to certain religious cults, such as the Hare Krishnas, where a drastic change in appearance was required for consideration as a total convert (Rochford, 1985). The punk counterculture informally imposed the same prerequisite. By doing something so out of the ordinary to their appearance, the punks voluntarily deprived themselves of some of the larger society's coveted goods.

For example, many of the hardcores were desperately poor. They said that they knew all they would have to do to obtain a job would be to grow their hair into a conventional style; yet they refused. This kind of action based on commitment was what Becker (1960) has called "side bets," where committed people act in such ways that affect their other interests separate and apart from their commitment interests. By making specific choices, people who are committed sacrifice the possible benefits of their other roles. An important characteristic of Becker's notion of side bets is that people are fully aware of the potential ramifications of their actions. This point was illustrated by one punk:

Some of my friends that aren't punk say, "Why don't you get a job? All you'd have to do is grow your hair out or get a wig and you could get a job." I mean, I know I could. Don't they think I knew that when I did it? It was a big step when I finally cut my hair in a mohawk.

For the hardcore punk, being punk was worth the sacrifices; it was perceived as an inherently good quality. In this respect, the hardcores differed from other types of punks. They held the larger punk scene in esteem. As one loyal member said:

It really pisses me off when people act like ours is the only punk group in the world. They don't even care what bigger and better groups exist. If this whole thing ended tomorrow, they wouldn't care what happened to the whole punk scene.

The hardcores continually expressed their disgust with the local scene. Much like the hippies studied by Davis (1970), "the scene," in itself, was the message. While not enough people joined the group to satisfy the punks, they were, nonetheless, grateful that they had any kind of group environment to which they could attach themselves. The Glass Gun, with its regularly scheduled "punk night," nonhostile attitude toward them, and coterie of interested bystanders, at least gave them a place to express their

values collectively. It was essential in maintaining the group's solidarity and social organization.

SOFTCORE PUNKS

The softcore punks made up a larger portion of the local scene than the hardcores. There were around fifteen softcore punks. There was one fundamental difference between the hardcore and softcore punks. For the hardcores, it was not sufficient just to be antiestablishment or to wear one's hair in a certain way. Rather, one had to embody the punk lifestyle and ideology in all possible ways. As one hardcore punk put it:

Everybody thinks she is hardcore because she looks so hardcore. I mean, yeah, she has a mohawk, and she won't get a job and she says she's for anarchy, but she doesn't care that much about being punk. She likes all these different kinds of music and stuff. She seems sometimes like she is just in it for fun. She even says she'll be whatever's in when punk goes out!

The softcore punks lived similar lifestyles to the hardcores. However, the element of "seriousness" about the scene, so pervasive among the hardcores, was absent among the softcores. Visually, the two types were basically indistinguishable. They were different only in their level of commitment. The commitment for softcores was to the lifestyle and the image only, not to "punk" as an ideology or an intrinsically valuable good. The softcores made no pretense of concern for either the larger counterculture or the feeling of permanence about their punk roles. As one softcore, Beth, said:

Everyone thinks I am so serious about it because I have a mohawk. Some people just can't get past it. Sometimes I get tired of it. Other times, I like to play jokes on people; like another friend of mine who has a mohawk, we'll walk down the street and point at someone with regular hair and say, "Wow! Look at him, he's weird, he doesn't have a mohawk." The fact is, if everyone did have one, I'd do something different to my hair.

The softcores identified with the punk image only temporarily. This distinguished their level of commitment from the *conversion* of the hardcores. The softcores' interest in the scene had only to do with what it could offer them at the present time. While participating, they did what was considered a good job of being "punk." However, if a new cultural trend surfaced, it would be just as likely that they would use their energy effectively to create that particular image. As one softcore punk said:

I've spent time identifying myself as a hippie, then as a women's libber, then an ecologist, and now as a punk. I'm punk now, but I am in the process of changing into something else. I don't know what. I'm getting bored with this scene. But for now, if I'm gonna do it, I'll do it right.

The softcore punks were somewhat committed in that they participated in some of the more drastic elements of punk lifestyle. For example, softcores had their hair cut in severe ways, just like the hardcores. They were, at least temporarily, committed to being punk (or playing punk) in that they "cut" themselves off from some of society's goods as well. However, the softcores did not share the self-destructive bent of the hardcores. The drugs that they consumed, such as marijuana, alcohol, and amphetamines, were not so potentially dangerous. Yet, because of their apparent visual commitment, and because of the lip service they gave to punk values, softcores were viewed as members in good standing. The hardcores liked and respected the softcores; the two groups associated freely. Some hardcores considered softcores to be simply members in transition. Lofland and Stark (1965) have suggested that movements themselves play a role in promoting the ideology in the new members, rather than the members coming to the movement because its ideology coincides with their own established beliefs. This was the case for the softcore punks. They did not claim to have held punk values before becoming punk. As Anne, a softcore, recalled:

It was scary to me at first. The hype from the magazines and stuff—all this weird shit, y'know. Then I went there and just hung out. The reason it was frightening is that a lot of people had different ideas about life than me. And I had to change myself to be with them. I had to be more intense, be an outcast. It was exciting because there seemed to be an element of danger in it—like living on the edge.

A process of simply happening onto the scene was typical of softcore members. Many recounted the feelings of purposelessness that preceded the drift into the punk scene. This drift is similar to the drifts that occur in other deviant lifestyles (Matza, 1964). What Matza called the “mood of desperation” often caused people to drift into delinquency or deviant lifestyles. As Joanie said:

I was really doing nothing with my life and I just kinda accidentally came into the punk scene. I gradually got involved in it that way. The music, and the people to an extent, really raised my consciousness about the system.

Softcores' verbal recognition of punk attitudes, such as awareness of the system, helped to validate their punk performances. Hardcores felt that verbal commitment was an essential first step to further commitment. For this reason, the hardcores accepted the softcores and considered them to be genuine and authentic in their punk identity. Such identification with punk values, along with a typical punk lifestyle, made the distinction between hardcores and softcores difficult. Again, the distinction became clear only with regard to the level of commitment, or seriousness, of the two types. One softcore made this qualification more apparent:

They get mad at me and think I'm insincere or whatever 'cause I like to have fun. I take my politics serious, too, but I feel if you are here, you might as well enjoy it. They think being punk is so serious, they are depressed or stoned all the time.

This statement indicates that the hardcores defined the situation for the local scene. The hardcores decided what

differentiated real punks (or committed punks) from pretenders. The hardcores considered only themselves and the softcores to be real. The "realness" of a punk was based on the level of commitment. The level was judged on the basis of willingness to sacrifice other identities for the punk identity. To prove this, a member would have to make permanent his or her punk image. What the punk identity offered was status within its own subculture for those who could not or would not achieve it in conventional society (Cohen, 1955). However, commitment to the deviant identity did not stem from a forced label. On the contrary, commitment to the punk identity was a "self-enhancing attachment" (Goffman, in Stebbins, 1971). The punks' self-esteem was enhanced by the approval they received. It would follow, then, that the more consistent one's behavior was with the superficial signs of commitment, the more prestige one would be able to obtain. Doug, a softcore, commented on this aspect of subcultural prestige among the punks:

In their own way, they're elitist. It's kind of like because they're not part of the general run of things, because they've actually *chosen* to be rejected in a lot of cases, they've kind of set up their own little social order. It seems to me like it's based on, like a contest, who can be more cool than who. With the really hardcore punks, it's who can self-destruct first; in the name of punk, I guess.

The hardcores and the softcores used the same criteria to judge commitment. Both types agreed that the difference between them was their levels of commitment. Both types fully realized that the softcores did not share the same loyalty to, and identification with, the punk counterculture as a whole. Although both types expressed some commitment to the punk identity and lifestyle, they both realized that the hardcores viewed their own identities as permanent and the softcores' as temporary.

PREPPIE PUNKS

The preppie punks made up an even larger portion of the crowd at punk events. The preppies frequented the scene,

but approached it similarly to a costume party. They were concerned with the novelty and the fashion. The preppies bore some resemblance to Yablonsky's (1968) "plastic hippies" in that they were drawn to the excitement of the scene. Whereas the core members acted nonchalant and natural about being punk, the preppies could not hide their enthusiasm about being part of the scene. This feature contributed to the core members' perceptions of preppies as "not real" punks. As one core member said:

It really kills me when these preppie girls come up to me and say "Oh, wow, you're so punk; you're so new wave," like I'm really trying or something.

Preppie punks did not lead the lifestyle of the core members. The preppie punks tended to be from middle-class families, whereas the core punks were generally from lower- or working-class backgrounds.³ Preppie punks often lived with their parents; they tended to be younger, and were often in school or in respectable, system-sanctioned jobs. This quasi-commitment meant that preppies had to be able to turn the punk image on and off at will. For example, a preppie punk hairstyle, although short, was styled in such a versatile way that it could be manipulated to look punk sometimes and conventional at other times. Preppie fashion was much the same way. Mary, a typical preppie punk, put her regular clothes together in a way she thought would look punk. She ripped up her sorority T-shirt. She bought outfits that were advertised as having the "punk look." Her traditional bangs transformed into "punk" bangs, standing straight up using hair spray or setting gel. The distinguishing feature of preppie punks was the manufactured quality of their punk look. This obvious ability to change roles kept the preppies from being considered real or committed. The preppies were not willing to give anything up for a punk identity. As one softcore said:

They come in with their little punk outfits from Ms. Jordan's [an exclusive clothing store] and it's written all over 'em: money. They

think they can have their nice little jobs and their semipunk hairdo and live with mom and dad and be a real punk, too. Well, they can't.

Another said of preppies:

It's a little hard to take when you have nothing and they try to have everything. Having all that goes against punk. They gotta choose to not have it. Otherwise, they're just playing a game.

The preppies liked to disavow their punk association in situations that would sanction them negatively for such associations. This state of "dual commitments," in which they never had to reject the conventional world in order to be marginally a part of the group, was characteristic of preppie punks (Cohen, 1955). Kanter (1972) has described a process of conversion and commitment that is commonly found in communes. The first step in the process was the renunciation of previous identities. According to this model, the preppie punks would not be considered committed at all. Thus they could not have been categorized as punks in any meaningful sense. As one core member said, "Being 'punk' to them is like playing cowboys and Indians."

Criticizing and joking about the preppies made up a large portion of core members' conversations. Some truly disliked the preppies and others were flattered by their feeble attempts at imitation of core behavior. For example, when a preppie punk approached one core member, he rolled his eyes and said, "Here comes my fan club," with a half-embarrassed smile and a distinct look of pleasure on his face.

Also, the financial function that the preppies served to core members made them more tolerable. Preppies almost always had jobs or survived by their parents' support. Many of the core members subsisted on the continued generosity of their devout fans. The preppies were more than willing to help the other punks. Preppies sometimes offered hard-core financial help in the form of buying them groceries, driving them places, and providing them with cigarettes,

alcohol, and other drugs. Because of this, many punks felt that they could not afford to reject outwardly those who were less committed. As Anne said, "One of these days, this kindness is going to dry up."

Yet the joking and poking fun at preppies was a constant activity. It served to separate, for the committed punks, "us" from "them." It reinforced their sense of being the only real punks. Again the distinction made by core members was grounded in the preppies' attempts to play numerous roles. Haircut and clothing were the decisive clues. The real punks could spot a preppie from a distance; they never had to say a word. As one core member said,

Oh look, she's punked out her hair. Yes, we're impressed. Tomorrow she'll look just like a Barbie doll again.

Perhaps the most definitive statement separating the real punks from the preppies referred to lifestyle:

All I know is that I live this seven days a week, and they just do it on weekends.

The preppies, though, while definitely removed from core members, still played an important role in the scene.

SPECTATORS

The category of spectators referred to everyone who observed the scene fairly regularly, but were not punks themselves. This type consisted of, literally, "everyone else." They made up the largest portion of the crowd at the Glass Gun on any given night. They were different from the preppie punks in that they did not try to look punk. They made no pretense of commitment to the scene at all. They did not identify themselves as punks; they had no stake in the scene. Spectators consisted of all different types of people and varied in their occupations, clothes, and reasons for being there. The only common denominator this group shared was the desire to stand back and watch, rather than

to participate actively in punk activities. One spectator said of his involvement in this scene:

People on the fringe are usually voyeurs of a sort. They like to be on the receiver's end of what's happening. Maybe punk is really their alter-ego. And maybe that need is satisfied just by watching and pretending. That's how it is with me, anyway.

The spectators liked to observe the fashion, to listen to the music, and to be "in the know" about the scene. They were, in other words, punk appreciators.

For the most part, spectators on the fringe were ignored by the core members. They never received the attention that preppies did because they made no attempts to "play punk." However, if a spectator appeared on the scene looking completely antithetical to punk, core members would simply laugh or say something derogatory about them and drop the subject. For example, one time a hippie-looking character came in and one punk said, "Oh my God, I think we're in a time warp," to which another punk responded, "Maybe we should tell him that Woodstock's over and that it is 1983."

Following such statements, the punks would watch the spectator's reaction to the scene. For the most part, except as a diversion, the punks were uninterested in the spectators. They did not generally associate with them or talk about them much. Presumably this was the case because of the tremendous turnover in spectator membership.

Most spectators either slowly began to identify with the group (most core members started out as spectators) or stopped frequenting the punk events. There were, however, some loyal spectators. They would frequent the club. They knew most of the punks at least slightly. The punks generally liked this sort of spectator because they provided the punks with an audience. Every type of punk thrived on an audience. The punks needed people to shock. The spectator served that function. The attitude that the members had toward the spectators was one of tolerance and indifference. As one core member said of them:

They're into it for the novelty. It's like going to the circus for them, to be a part of something new and exciting. But that's okay. I like going to the circus, too; I just like being in it better.

Thus though spectators were only peripheral to the scene they provided an alternative set of norms that functioned to delineate the social boundaries of the counter-culture.

CONCLUSION

In this essay I have depicted a contemporary counter-culture composed of identity-seeking youths. Typical of the rebelliousness displayed by individuals questioning the values of society and their parents and seeking to establish their own selves, such youths engaged in deviant behavior and lifestyles. As a result, these youths have congregated into interrelations characterized by Best and Luckenbill (1982) as "deviant peers," engaging in deviant activities together and scrutinizing each others' actions. As deviant peers, they set their own standards for evaluating each other and used these as criteria for determining their membership status (Higgins and Butler, 1982).

The typologies they have articulated were based on the individual's commitment to the ideology, lifestyle, taste, and appearance of the movement. A hierarchy existed that ranged from the most involved, central members (hardcores and softcores) to the less involved, leisure members (prep-pies) to the peripheral nonmembers (spectators). Members of these different groups had different roles and served different functions for the local scene as a whole. Central members provided ideology, leadership, and entertainment for peripheral participants. They served as role models for the value system associated with the counterculture. The drama and shock value of their antiestablishment appearance and lifestyle added a further allure for peripheral members. Their function for the counterculture was most central and obvious.

The role of the peripheral members was more subtle. On the one hand, they served to *insulate* central members from society (Higgins and Butler, 1982). While central members functioned within the same society as conventional people, they lived in an isolated social world. They did not associate socially with "nonpunks." They did associate, though, with peripheral members. These people formed the audience, fan club, foil, and following for central members. The peripheral members thus served to nourish the egos of the central members and reinforce their punk image. They were the only noncentral members whom the hardcores and softcores accepted socially, albeit as followers more than as friends. On the other hand, the peripheral members also served as a *conduit* between central members and conventional society. They helped sustain the core members' existence financially. They provided such assistance both directly, in the form of handouts of food or cigarettes, and indirectly by patronizing their club (thus helping it continue to exist) and driving them to pick up their welfare checks. It is, I believe, characteristic of antiestablishment countercultures in general for members to subsist parasitically on the societies that they oppose. Further, the peripheral members served as a conduit to conventional society by contributing an acceptable degree of societal norms to the group. It is characteristic of countercultures to have their share of hangers-on, or unauthentic members (Yinger, 1982). However, these members serve definite functions for the maintenance of the whole. The peripheral groups thus filled ironically polarized roles: buffering the central members from contact, yet, at the same time, maintaining contact for them with the conventional society.

The punks I studied seemed to share many of the characteristics of countercultural groups in general. A counterculture's expression occurs in response to the specific conditions of modern society, or the culture in particular of which it is critical. The state of consciousness or ideology of a counterculture functions as what Brake

(1985: 15) has called a "magical" solution, in that the viability of the alternative is more imaged than real. However, their rather ineffectual form of protest is functional for the larger society as well. These manifestations of discontent serve to appease the disgruntled by convincing them of the validity of their solution, while remaining fundamentally nonthreatening to the structure of the dominant culture.

Presumably it is characteristic for countercultures to have varying levels of commitment within them. The most committed segment of a counterculture is necessarily the most disengaged from the dominant society. However, for a counterculture to have any significant effect on a society, there must be some degree of interplay between these polarized groups. The marginally committed stratum, which continues to operate and function within conventional society, serves as the connection between the two factions. This stratum serves as the mediator between the dominant culture and the counterculture, informing both of the other side's presence and position. Thus the marginal group plays an essential role in the efflorescence of a counterculture. Without this indirect link to the larger society, a counterculture, by virtue of its definitive elements, would exist in insignificant isolation. The intent of the counterculture is to be recognized and responded to by the society. Thus for a counterculture to be effective and useful, for both itself and the dominant culture, the different levels of commitment are necessary. The core stratum provides the "counter" ideology and the opposition to the status quo. The marginal stratum facilitates the dialogue between the counterculture and the dominant culture that it opposes.

Many other structural analyses have been conducted about youth countercultures in the past, examining the members' roles and functions for the group. Future researchers on the subject could investigate the relationship between different levels of commitment within a deviant subculture and the members' class, educational, and ethnic

backgrounds, as well as the processes by which they become committed to the counterculture.

NOTES

1. I am indebted to David Matza and John Torpey for this analogy.
2. With the exception of the term *softcore*, all of the distinctions between categories came directly from the participants. The members did make a distinction between hardcore and what I am calling softcore punks. However, the softcores were referred to simply as "punks" by the hardcores, in an effort to distinguish the "hardcore" quality they attributed to themselves. I chose to refrain from using the term *punk* to apply to one specific category so that I can use the term more freely and generally, and to avoid confusion.
3. Very little information is provided in this text about the class, race, and ethnicity of these participants. The community from which these data come is relatively homogeneous. The few references to class are more impressionistic; that is, based upon knowledge of family occupations, school districts, and so on. However, the dearth of this kind of data stems from the fact that I was more interested in the features the members had in common than in the distinctions between them, with the exception of their differing levels of commitment and their styles.

REFERENCES

- ADLER, P. A. (1985) *Wheeling and Dealing*. New York: Columbia Univ. Press.
- BECKER, H. S. (1960) "Notes on the concept of commitment," *Amer. J. of Sociology* 66: 32-40.
- BERGER, B. (1967) "Hippie morality—more old than new." *Transaction* 5: 19-27.
- BEST, J. and D. LUCKENBILL (1982) *Organizing Deviance*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.
- BRAKE, M. (1980) *The Sociology of Youth Culture and Youth Subcultures*. London: Routledge.
- BRAKE, M. (1985) *Comparative Youth Culture: The Sociology of Youth Culture and Subcultures in America, Britain, and Canada*. London: Routledge.
- COHEN, A. (1955) *Delinquent Boys*. Glencoe, IL: Free Press.
- COHEN, S. (1972) *Folk Devils and Moral Panics*. New York: St. Martin's.
- DAVIS, F. (1970) "Focus on the flower children: why all of us may be hippies some day," pp. 327-340 in J. Douglas (ed.) *Observations of Deviance*. New York: Random House.
- DAVIS, F. and L. MUNOZ (1968) "Heads and freaks: patterns and meanings of drug use among hippies," *J. of Health and Social Behavior* 9: 156-164.

- DOUGLAS, J. (1970) *Youth in Turmoil*. Washington, DC: National Institute of Mental Health.
- DOUGLAS, J. (1976) *Investigative Social Research*. Newbury Park, CA: Sage.
- FLACKS, R. (1967) "The liberated generation: an exploration of the roots of student protest." *J. of Social Issues* 23: 52-75.
- FLACKS, R. (1971) *Youth and Social Change*. Chicago: Markham.
- FRITH, S. (1982) *Sound Effects*. New York: Pantheon.
- HALL, S. and T. JEFFERSON [eds.] (1975) *Resistance Through Rituals*. London: Hutchinson.
- HEBDIGE, D. (1981) *Subcultures: The Meaning of Style*. New York: Methuen.
- HENSLIN, J. (1972) "Studying deviance in four settings: research experiences with cabbies, suicides, drug users, and abortionees," pp. 35-70 in J. Douglas (ed.) *Research on Deviance*. New York: Random House.
- HIGGINS, J. and R. BUTLER (1982) *Understanding Deviance*. New York: McGraw-Hill.
- KANTER, R. M. (1972) *Commitment and Community: Communes and Utopia in Sociological Perspective*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard Univ. Press.
- KINSEY, B. A. (1982) "Killum and eatum: identity consolidation in a middle class poly-drug abuse subculture." *Symbolic Interaction* 5: 311-324.
- LOFLAND, J. and R. STARK (1965) "Becoming a world saver: a theory of conversion to a deviant perspective." *Amer. Soc. Rev.* 30: 862-875.
- MATZA, D. (1964) *Delinquency and Drift*. New York: John Wiley.
- MILLER, W. (1958) "Lower class culture as a generating milieu of gang delinquency." *J. of Social Issues* 14: 5-19.
- MUNGHAM, G. and G. PEARSON [eds.] (1976) *Working Class Youth Culture*. London: Routledge.
- PFOHL, S. (1985) *Images of Deviance and Social Control*. New York: McGraw-Hill.
- ROCHFORD, E.B., Jr., (1985) *Hare Krishnas in America*. New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers Univ. Press.
- SNOW, D. A., E. B. ROCHFORD, Jr., S. K. WORDEN, and R. D. BENFORD (1986) "Frame alignment and mobilization." *Amer. Soc. Rev.* 51: 464-481.
- SNOW, D. A., L. ZURCHER, Jr., and S. EKLAND-OLSON (1980) "Social networks and social movements: a micro-structural approach to differential recruitment." *Amer. Soc. Rev.* 45: 787-801.
- STEBBINS, R. A. (1971) *Commitment to Deviance*. Westport, CT: Greenwood.
- STREET, J. (1986) *Rebel Rock: The Politics of Popular Music*. Oxford: Basil Blackwell.
- SYKES, G. and D. MATZA (1957) "Techniques of neutralization." *Amer. Soc. Rev.* 22: 664-670.
- TAYLOR, I. (1982) "Moral enterprise, moral panic, and law-and-order campaigns," pp. 123-149 in M. M. Rosenberg et al. (eds.) *A Sociology of Deviance*. New York: St. Martin's.
- YABLONSKY, L. (1959) "The delinquent gang as a near-group." *Social Problems* 7: 108-117.
- YABLONSKY, L. (1962) *The Violent Gang*. New York: Macmillan.
- YABLONSKY, L. (1968) *The Hippie Trip*. New York: Pegasus.
- YINGER, J. M. (1982) *Countercultures: The Promise and Peril of a World Turned Upside Down*. New York: Free Press.

YOUNG, J. (1973) "The hippie solution: an essay in the politics of leisure," pp. 182-208 in I. Taylor and L. Taylor (eds.) *Politics and Deviance*. Harmondsworth, England: Penguin.

KATHRYN JOAN FOX is a graduate student at the University of California at Berkeley in the Department of Sociology. She is currently involved in research on Bohemianism in Western culture. Her areas of interest are deviance, popular culture, and the presentation of self.